

**DENVER COUNTY DEPARTMENT OF
HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES**

OFFICE OF THE MEDICAL EXAMINER

REPORT OF AUTOPSY EXAMINATION

ENVIRONMENT

DATE OF EXAM: 11-11-2011

TIME OF EXAM: 12:48 PM

PHYSICIAN: Jackson Finch, M.D.

AUTHORIZED BY: Marisha Romero, Chief of Police

LOCATION: Three Pines, CO

CASE ID: 83-00224H

AUTOPSY ID: 48101-090

DECEDENT

NAME:

AGE:

SEX:

RACE:

LENGTH:

WEIGHT:

EYES:

HAIR:

Nathan LaPalma

62 years

M

White

73.2"

172 lbs.

Blue

Brown

MANNER OF DEATH: Homicide

ANATOMIC FINDINGS:

1. Deceased adult male with incised cut throat injury and early signs of rigor mortis and postmortem lividity.
2. Mechanism of death is exsanguination by a cut throat.
3. Additional perimortem trauma to the back of the head and elbow.

CAUSE OF DEATH:

From the anatomic findings and pertinent history, I ascribe death to:

(A) Hemorrhagic shock

Due to or as a consequence of:

(B) Severe lacerations across the neck from the right exterior jugular through the carotid artery

Due to or as a consequence of:

(C) The edges of an isolated 10" skate blade sharpened to a 0.5" radius of hollow

TIME OF DEATH:

Paramedics recorded the official time of death on scene at 10:29 AM, but given the algor, rigor, and livor mortis upon discovery, the best approximation of time of death is up to fifteen minutes before declaration.

CIRCUMSTANTIAL SUMMARY:

The decedent was a Caucasian male found in a supine position with blood pooling beneath on the ice's surface at the Three Pines Ice Rink at 10:17 AM after practice had concluded. The victim suffered two severe parallel lacerations to the neck that severed the exterior and interior jugular veins and common carotid artery. An unattached blade of a figure skate matching the dimensions of the injury was left at the scene and recovered by the Three Pines Police Department.

Given the angle and force required to commit this act, the mortal wounds were almost certainly not self-inflicted.

IDENTIFICATION:

Emergency responders completed a postmortem examination on the body of Nathan LaPalma, who was originally identified by reporting party Kingston Lee and confirmed by the driver's license found on the body.

COMPLETED:

Jackson Finch, M.D.

EVIDENCE EXAMINED

Clothing and Valuables:

1. Gray pullover
2. Burgundy athletic shirt
3. Black athletic sweatpants
4. Black underwear
5. Gray argyle socks
6. Size 9.5 men's figure skates (2), guards included
7. Smartphone, found 2.3 ft from the right-hand side
8. Keyring with keys (4)
9. Vicuna cigarettes (18)
10. Blue Label lighter
11. Wallet, containing:
 - a. Driver's license
 - b. Cash totaling \$40.50
 - c. Credit cards (3)
 - d. ASA membership card
 - e. Free birthday taco coupon
 - f. Photo of dog with note: "Lutz's first day home!"

Photograph(s): Taken by the Three Pines Police Department, filed under Report #224-002513.

Toxicology: Tissue samples of major organs were collected for examination. Extraneous blood samples were contaminated from the sampling methods on unclean ice and are still under review.

Other: Crime report and telephone call with Marisha Romero, Three Pines Chief of Police

EXTERNAL EXAMINATION

The decedent presents as a well-developed and nourished Caucasian male with a cut against the anterior of the throat. The laceration is consistent with the width of the skate blade found at the scene. Two parallel entry and exit wounds are present. The angle of the deepest cut is acute, suggesting that the edges of the blade made contact with the skin from a direction below the chin. Postmortem bruising along the right side of the wound and internal structures of the neck suggests that the assailant struck from the victim's right side and is likely right-handed. Slight cranial bruising present on the back of the head and left elbow as well as 1st-2nd degree abrasions on the left elbow with absent particulate suggest the victim may have slid or fallen against the ice just before death. There is very little evidence of skin decomposition. Paramedics took the temperature of the body on the ice as 98.21° F with the ice known to be 23.6° F in the 53° F ambient.

INJURIES

Notes: No artifacts of medical or postmortem care are present.

Injuries of the Neck: Two parallel entry slits approximately 0.189" apart combine into one gash that stretches across the anterior of the neck, cutting through jugular veins and the common carotid artery. The cut closest to the clavicle spanned 4.89" in length and had a maximum depth of 1.50" with an entry angle of approximately 45°. The second followed the same path as the first and measured 4.87" x 1.49". Victim experienced severe, rapid, and fatal blood loss from these wounds.

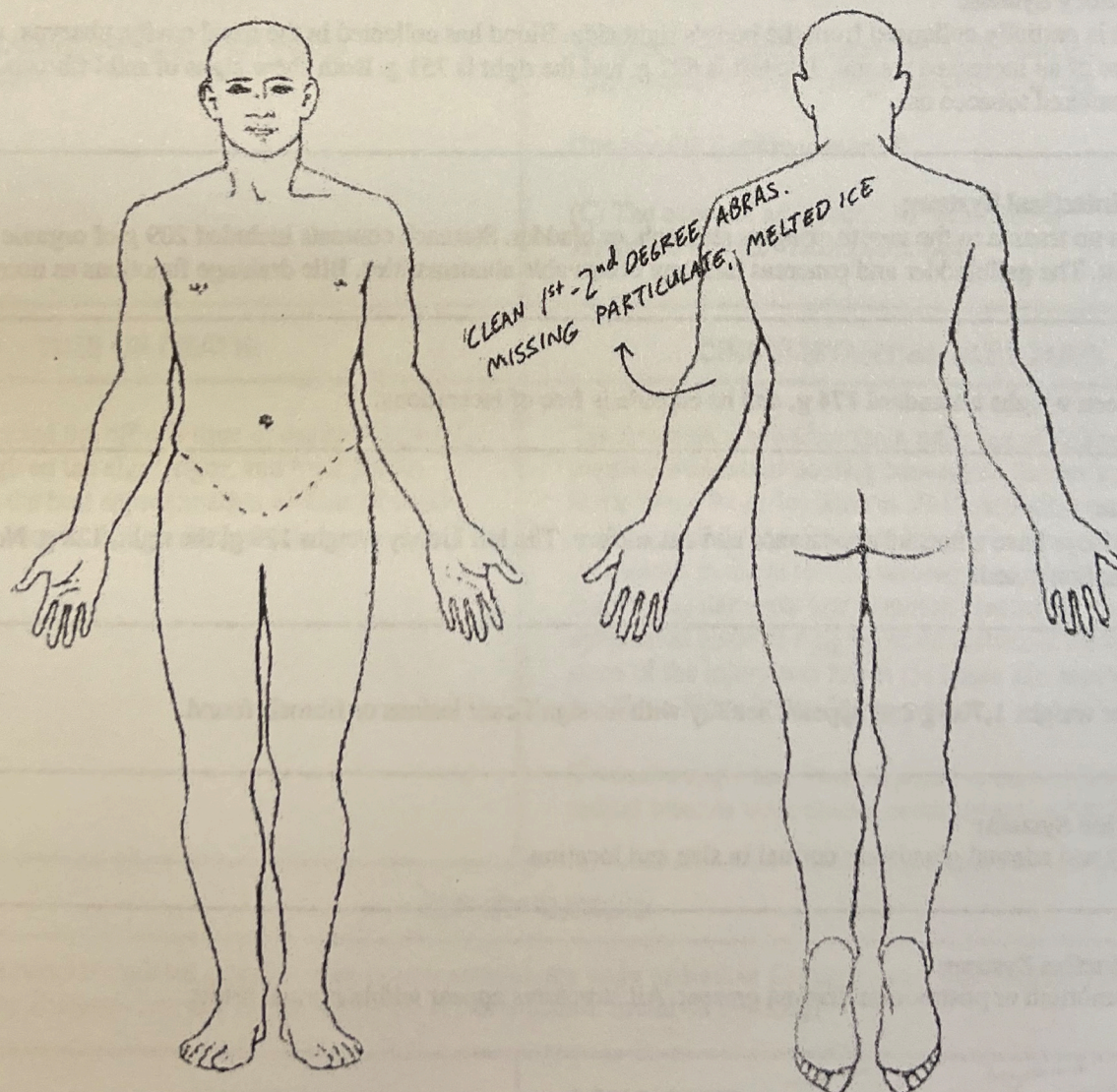
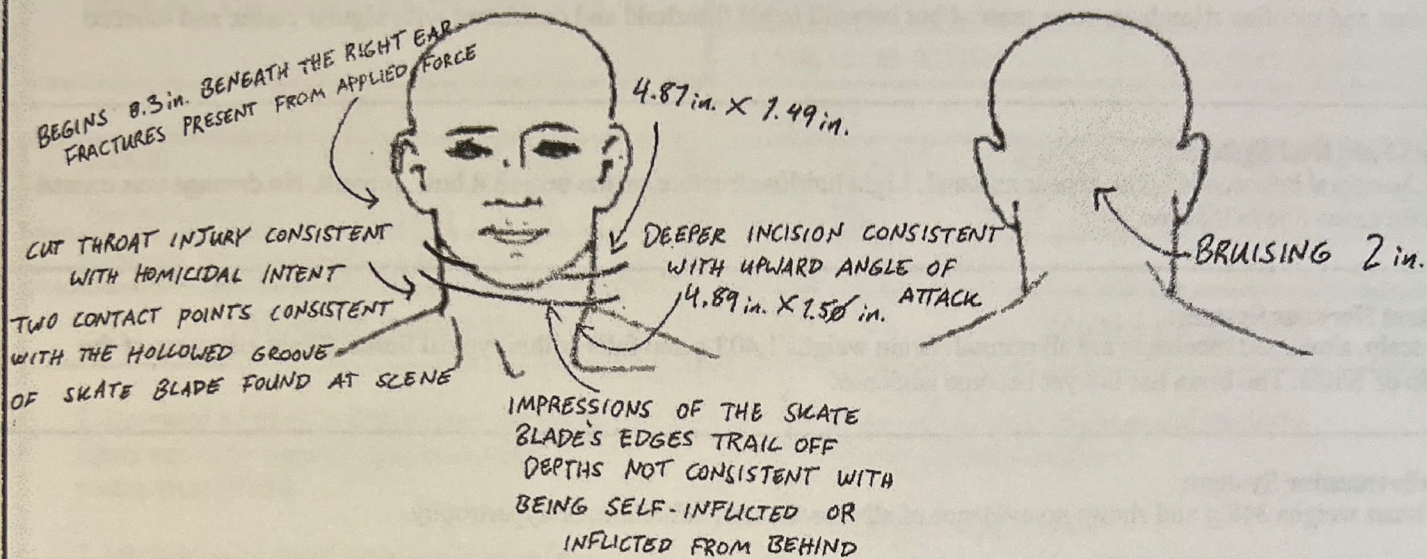
Additional blunt force injuries were acquired from the blow of the blade. Most notably, the trachea partially collapsed on the right side, and the thyroid cartilage sustained a minute fracture.

Injuries of the Cubital Area: Perimortem trauma to the left elbow, three 1st-2nd degree abrasions, are consistent with the victim slipping, falling, or being pushed onto his back shortly before death.

Injuries of the Cranium: Perimortem blunt trauma not severe enough to have caused death. Bleeding was contained to a 2" bruise against the occipital bone. Injury likely caused the victim to be disoriented and/or fall unconscious.

MARKS AND WOUNDS

* NOT TO SCALE



INTERNAL EXAMINATION

Preliminary Toxicology:

Residual blood, saliva, and urine samples from the victim's body passed screenings for alcohol, analgesics, antidepressants, antihistamines, antipsychotics, benzodiazepines, cannabis, cardiovasculars, cocaine, and narcotics.

Caffeine and nicotine stimulants were present but beneath lethal threshold and consistent with regular coffee and tobacco use.

Musculoskeletal System:

Ribs, vertebral bones, and spine appear as usual. Light hairline fracture on the occipital bone present. No damage was caused to brain tissue due to injuries.

Central Nervous System:

The scalp, skull, and meninges are all normal. Brain weighs 1,403 g and falls within typical limits. Slight atheroma of the Circle of Willis. The brain has not yet become isodense.

Cardiovascular System:

The heart weighs 348 g and shows no evidence of atherosclerosis, infarction, or hypertrophy.

Respiratory System:

Trachea is partially collapsed from the body's right side. Blood has collected in the nasal cavity, pharynx, and bronchi. Both lungs are of an increased weight. The left is 692 g, and the right is 751 g. Both show signs of mild fibrosis consistent with casual smoked tobacco use.

Gastrointestinal System:

There is no trauma to the mouth, tongue, stomach, or bladder. Stomach contents included 209 g of organic material, a light breakfast. The gallbladder and pancreas lack any observable abnormalities. Bile drainage functions as normal.

Spleen:

The spleen weighs a standard 174 g, and its capsule is free of lacerations.

Kidneys:

Both kidneys have a normal appearance and cut surface. The left kidney weighs 129 g; the right, 128 g. No significant inflammation noted.

Liver:

The liver weighs 1,705 g and appears healthy with no significant lesions or fibrosis found.

Endocrine System:

Pituitary and adrenal glands are normal in size and location.

Reproductive System:

No antemortem or postmortem trauma present. All structures appear within normal limits.